STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

BURNOUT AND WORKLOAD

How often people feel burned out, pressure in Germany and Europe, what the WHO counts as burnout, Gallup's five factors, six areas of worklife, and a card for a talk about workload.

28% of full-time employees feel burned out at work very often or always, in a 2019 study of 12,658.

GALLUP, 2020

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In this issue

Burnout is often treated as a personal problem. The WHO places it in the job: chronic stress at work that has not been managed. How common is it, what goes with it, and what can a manager change in the work itself?

In a 2019 Gallup study, 28% of full-time employees felt burned out very often or always. In Germany 48% often work under strong deadline or performance pressure; in the EU 44% report severe time pressure or overload. The WHO counts burnout as an occupational phenomenon, not a medical condition. Gallup links it most strongly to unfair treatment, unmanageable workload, unclear roles, little support from the manager and unreasonable time pressure; Maslach and Leiter name six areas where job and person may not fit.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

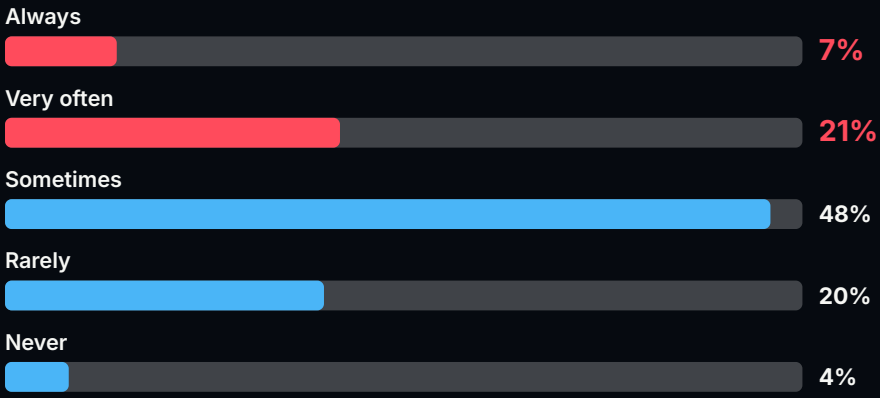
Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

More than one in four

In a 2019 study Gallup asked 12,658 full-time employees how often they feel burned out at work. 28% answered very often or always; 76% at least sometimes.

HOW OFTEN FULL-TIME EMPLOYEES FEEL BURNED OUT AT WORK (2019)



In 2018 Gallup reported on nearly 7,500 full-time employees: 23% very often or always, and 44% sometimes. The samples differ, so the two figures do not make a trend.

OUR READING

The largest group is the 48% who answer sometimes. Burnout comes in degrees; the rare extreme cases are only the visible end.

Sources: Gallup, 2020; Ben Wigert & Sangeeta Agrawal, Gallup, 2018

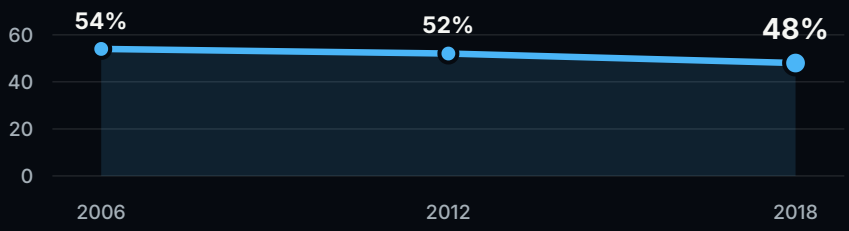
These are self-reports, with no medical diagnosis behind them; Gallup's 2020 report draws on its US panel.

THE NUMBERS

Pressure in Germany and Europe

The German BIBB/BAuA survey of 2018 asked 20,012 employed people about their work. 48% of employees often work under strong deadline or performance pressure, fewer than in 2006 and 2012.

OFTEN UNDER STRONG DEADLINE OR PERFORMANCE PRESSURE, GERMANY



Of those exposed, 67% feel burdened by it, up from 65% in 2012. In spring 2025 EU-OSHA asked over 28,000 workers in the EU, Iceland and Norway by telephone. In the EU:

44% report severe time pressure or overload

34% report a lack of rewards for their efforts

29% report poor communication or cooperation

Sources: Bundesanstalt für Arbeitsschutz und Arbeitsmedizin (BAuA), 2020; EU-OSHA, 2025

Self-reports; the German figures are from 2018, the EU-OSHA ones are EU averages. For Albania we have no comparable data on burnout.

THE MODEL

What the WHO counts as burnout

In May 2019 the World Health Organization included burn-out in its International Classification of Diseases, ICD-11, as an occupational phenomenon. “It is not classified as a medical condition.”

It describes a syndrome resulting from chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed, with three dimensions:

01
Exhaustion
feelings of energy depletion or exhaustion

02
Distance
more mental distance from one's job, or negativism or cynicism about it

03
Efficacy
reduced professional efficacy

It refers only to work and should not be used for other areas of life. In ICD-11 it has the code QD85, among problems associated with employment, in the chapter on factors influencing health status, not among the diseases. ICD-11 came into effect on 1 January 2022.

OUR READING

The definition points at work: stress at work that has not been managed. That gives a manager a clear job, the work, and leaves any diagnosis to doctors.

Sources: World Health Organization, 2019; World Health Organization, 2025

The current ICD-11 entry words the third dimension as a sense of ineffectiveness and lack of accomplishment. This issue describes a definition and gives no medical advice.

More in the essay Leading people without losing the person

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

What goes with burnout

In 2018 Ben Wigert and Sangeeta Agrawal of Gallup named the five factors most strongly linked to burnout among about 7,500 full-time employees.

Gallup's order, 2018

1. unfair treatment at work
2. unmanageable workload
3. lack of role clarity
4. lack of communication and support from the manager
5. unreasonable time pressure

2.3×
as likely to report high burnout, for those often treated unfairly at work

≈ 70%
less likely to feel burned out regularly, for those who feel supported by their manager

70%
less likely to report high burnout, for those who often or always have enough time for all their work

Employees who felt burned out were 63% more likely to take a sick day and 2.6 times as likely to be actively looking for another job.

OUR READING

All five factors are decided at work, which gives a manager a place to look first.

Sources: Ben Wigert & Sangeeta Agrawal, Gallup, 2018; Gallup, 2020

These associations rest on self-reports and do not prove cause. In 2020 Gallup put unclear communication from managers and lack of manager support in third and fourth place.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Where the job does not fit

Christina Maslach and Michael Leiter describe six areas of worklife in which a person and the job can be mismatched. The bigger the mismatch, the more likely burnout; the better the match, the more likely engagement.

01
Workload
Can the work be done in the time there is?

02
Control
Who decides how the work is done?

03
Reward
Is the effort seen and rewarded?

04
Community
Do people help each other?

05
Fairness
Are work and decisions shared fairly?

06
Values
Does the work fit what people think is right?

A meta-analysis by Eean Crawford, Jeffery LePine and Bruce Rich found that job demands go with more burnout, and job resources with less burnout and more engagement. Demands that people see as hindrances go with less engagement; demands they see as challenges, with more.

Sources: Christina Maslach & Michael P. Leiter, World Psychiatry, 2016; Eean R. Crawford, Jeffery A. LePine & Bruce L. Rich, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2010 (via Abstract)

The questions are the editors', after the six areas. The links are correlations, not proof of cause; Maslach and Leiter note that few studies evaluate interventions.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The workload talk

Fifteen minutes, one to one, every few weeks. The talk stays on the work and keeps clear of health: the manager listens, asks, and writes down one change.

01 Load what is on the list this week, and what could wait

02 Time where deadlines collide, and who set them

03 Decisions what you can decide yourself, and where you wait for others

04 Fairness where work or credit feels unevenly shared

05 Support what I can take off, decide or ask for on your behalf

06 One change what, who, by when; look at it again next time

Sources: Ben Wigert & Sangeeta Agrawal, Gallup, 2018; Christina Maslach & Michael P. Leiter, World Psychiatry, 2016

The editors' proposal for practice, after Gallup's five factors (2018) and the six areas of worklife. It does not replace medical help.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Gallup's Perspective on Employee Burnout: Causes and Cures
Gallup, 2020
https://www.gallup.com/file/workplace/282668/Gallups%20Perspective%20on%20Employee%20Burnout%20Causes%20and%20Cures.pdf

OSH Pulse 2025: Occupational safety and health in the era of climate and digital change
EU-OSHA, 2025
https://osha.europa.eu/en/publications/osh-pulse-2025-occupational-safety-and-health-era-climate-and-digital-change

Understanding the burnout experience: recent research and its implications for psychiatry
Christina Maslach & Michael P. Leiter, World Psychiatry, 2016
https://doi.org/10.1002/wps.20311

Linking job demands and resources to employee engagement and burnout: A theoretical extension and meta-analytic test
Eean R. Crawford, Jeffery A. LePine & Bruce L. Rich, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2010 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.1037/a0019364

Burn-out an "occupational phenomenon": International Classification of Diseases
World Health Organization, 2019
https://www.who.int/news/item/28-05-2019-burn-out-an-occupational-phenomenon-international-classification-of-diseases

Stressreport Deutschland 2019
Bundesanstalt für Arbeitsschutz und Arbeitsmedizin (BAuA), 2020
https://www.baua.de/EN/Service/Publications/Report/Stress-report-2019

Employee Burnout, Part 1: The 5 Main Causes
Ben Wigert & Sangeeta Agrawal, Gallup, 2018
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/237059/employee-burnout-part-main-causes.aspx

ICD-11 for Mortality and Morbidity Statistics (2025-01): QD85 Burnout
World Health Organization, 2025
https://icd.who.int/browse/2025-01/mms/en#129180281

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked "via". The editors' interpretation is marked "Our reading". Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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